



INFERENCE QUESTIONS

SAT Reading & Writing — “Most Logically Completes the Text”

Theory, worked examples, and process of elimination



WHAT AN INFERENCE ANSWER MUST DO

- The correct answer must be true given the passage — not clever, not persuasive
- No outside knowledge and no new assumptions — use only what the passage states
- The right answer is often a restatement, a combination, or a narrow deduction of two stated facts
- Scan the passage for conditionals, comparisons, quantities, and shifts between groups (“most” vs. “all”)
- Verify a candidate answer by asking: could this be false given the passage? If yes, eliminate it

FOUR WRONG-ANSWER TRAPS

Too strong

absolute language — all, never, only, every — the passage does not support

Out of scope

brings in a factor the passage never mentions

Reversed logic

flips a stated conditional ($A \rightarrow B$ is treated as $B \rightarrow A$)

Plausible but unproven

sounds reasonable, but the passage never guarantees it

“MOST LOGICALLY COMPLETES THE TEXT”

- This is an inference subtype: the blank sits at the end of the passage
- The completion must be forced by the prior sentences — not just a sentence that fits the topic
- Everything before the blank is a set of premises leading to one necessary conclusion
- Watch for a pivot word right before the blank — therefore, thus, however, in fact — it signals what kind of conclusion is required
- If a fact is stated twice from two angles (e.g., a result and a possible cause the passage rules out), the blank usually resolves that tension

QUICK TEST

The best inference is the one you could defend using only quotes and facts from the passage — no extra reasoning, no outside knowledge, no benefit of the doubt.

EXAMPLE 1

ENVIRONMENTAL SCIENCE

A recent study of urban beekeeping tracked colony survival rates in three mid-sized cities over five years. Researchers found that colonies kept within a quarter mile of public parks had survival rates nearly twice as high as colonies kept in purely residential areas without nearby parks. Further analysis showed that the parks in the study contained significantly more flowering plant diversity than residential yards, which typically featured a narrow range of ornamental species. The researchers also noted that colonies near parks were exposed to no less pesticide use than colonies in residential areas, since many of the parks bordered heavily sprayed athletic fields.

Based on the results, the researchers concluded that _____

- A** pesticide exposure is the primary factor determining urban colony survival rates.
- B** colonies located near parks will always survive longer than those in purely residential areas.
- C** plant diversity, rather than pesticide exposure, likely accounts for the difference in survival rates.
- D** residential beekeepers should relocate their colonies to public parks.

EXAMPLE 1 — PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

ELIMINATE

A

Contradicted — the passage states park colonies faced equal, not lower, pesticide exposure, so pesticide exposure cannot explain the higher survival rate.

ELIMINATE

B

Too strong — “always” is not supported; the study reports a survival-rate difference, not a guarantee.

CORRECT

C

Forced by elimination — pesticide exposure was equal across groups, so the one stated difference (plant diversity) is what the evidence points to.

ELIMINATE

D

Out of scope — the passage reports a finding, not a recommendation for beekeepers to act on.

EXAMPLE 2

U.S. HISTORY

Textile mills in the early nineteenth century typically recruited young unmarried women from rural areas, offering wages that, while modest, exceeded what these women could earn locally. Boardinghouses attached to the mills provided room and board, chaperonage, and required attendance at evening lectures. Company records indicate that turnover among mill workers was extremely high, with the average worker remaining less than four years before returning home or marrying. Historians have also found that many workers used their wages to fund their brothers' or younger siblings' education rather than saving for their own long-term needs.

Given this evidence, it is most reasonable to conclude that _____

- A** mill work was intended by most workers as a permanent career rather than a temporary arrangement.
- B** many mill workers viewed their employment as a temporary means of contributing to family goals rather than a lasting vocation.
- C** mill owners were primarily motivated by a desire to educate rural women.
- D** wages paid to mill workers were insufficient to cover the cost of room and board.

EXAMPLE 2 — PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

ELIMINATE

A Contradicted — average tenure under four years and departures for marriage point away from a permanent career.

CORRECT

B Restates two combined facts — short average tenure and wages directed toward siblings' education — as one necessary conclusion.

ELIMINATE

C Out of scope — the passage describes required lectures, not the owners' underlying motivation.

ELIMINATE

D Out of scope — no comparison between wages and boarding costs is given in the passage.

EXAMPLE 3

BIOLOGY

A wetland restoration project reintroduced a native reed species to a marsh previously dominated by an invasive grass. Within two growing seasons, populations of a wading bird that had been nearly absent from the marsh for a decade rebounded significantly. Researchers observed that the reintroduced reed grows in dense stands that provide nesting cover unavailable in the invasive grass, which grows in a low, uniform mat. However, water chemistry tests taken before and after the reed's reintroduction showed no significant change in nutrient levels or salinity, and fish surveys conducted over the same period showed no meaningful shift in prey abundance for the birds.

It can most logically be concluded that _____

- A** the invasive grass had been directly toxic to the wading birds.
- B** the rebound in the wading bird population was most plausibly linked to the availability of nesting cover rather than to changes in water quality or food supply.
- C** the invasive grass will now be eliminated from the marsh entirely.
- D** wading bird populations depend primarily on fish abundance rather than nesting habitat.

EXAMPLE 3 — PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

ELIMINATE

A

Out of scope — no toxicity data appears anywhere in the passage.

CORRECT

B

Forced by elimination — water chemistry and prey abundance stayed constant, leaving nesting cover as the one factor that changed.

ELIMINATE

C

Too strong — nothing in the passage addresses whether the invasive grass persists or spreads elsewhere in the marsh.

ELIMINATE

D

Reversed logic — fish abundance did not change, so it cannot be the primary driver of the rebound described.

EXAMPLE 4

ECONOMICS

When a regional airline introduced a dynamic pricing model that adjusted ticket prices in real time based on demand, analysts expected overall revenue to rise, since prices during high-demand periods increased substantially. Contrary to this expectation, the airline's quarterly revenue remained roughly flat compared to the previous pricing system. Internal data revealed that while high-demand flights did generate more revenue per seat, the number of tickets sold during low-demand periods dropped sharply, since the algorithm set prices on some routes so low that the airline reduced the frequency of those flights to cut losses. Customer surveys further indicated that many travelers who had previously booked low-demand flights shifted to competitor airlines rather than pay the new peak prices.

Based on this information, it would be most logical to conclude that _____

- A** dynamic pricing is generally an ineffective strategy for the airline industry as a whole.
- B** the gains in per-seat revenue from high-demand flights were largely offset by losses in ticket volume and reduced flight frequency during low-demand periods.
- C** customers were unaffected by the change in pricing structure.
- D** the airline's competitors also adopted dynamic pricing models in response.

EXAMPLE 4 — PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

ELIMINATE

A Too strong / out of scope — one airline's flat revenue cannot be generalized to the entire industry.

CORRECT

B Combines the stated facts — higher per-seat revenue on one side, lower volume and reduced frequency on the other — to explain the flat total.

ELIMINATE

C Contradicted — the survey shows customers shifted to competitor airlines.

ELIMINATE

D Out of scope — the passage never describes competitors' pricing decisions.

EXAMPLE 5

PSYCHOLOGY

A researcher studying decision-making gave two groups of participants an identical set of investment options, but described potential outcomes differently: one group received information framed in terms of potential gains, while the other received the same information framed in terms of potential losses. Participants in the loss-framed group consistently chose the safer, lower-return option at a higher rate than those in the gain-framed group, even though the actual probabilities and payouts were mathematically identical across both framings. When the researcher repeated the experiment using a group of professional financial analysts instead of the general public, the same pattern emerged, though the difference in the analysts' rates of choosing the safer option was smaller than that observed among nonexperts.

The researcher concluded that _____

- A** professional experience with financial decisions eliminates the effect of framing on choice.
- B** the way outcome information is framed can influence decision-making even among individuals with relevant expertise.
- C** loss-framed information is always more persuasive than gain-framed information regardless of audience.
- D** financial analysts are less capable than the general public of assessing mathematically identical probabilities.

EXAMPLE 5 — PROCESS OF ELIMINATION

ELIMINATE

A Too strong — the passage says the effect was smaller among analysts, not that it disappeared.

CORRECT

B Directly forced — the same framing pattern appeared for analysts, only reduced in size, so framing still had an effect on experts.

ELIMINATE

C Too strong — “always” and “regardless of audience” go beyond what two tested groups can establish.

ELIMINATE

D Reversed / unsupported — the passage describes susceptibility to framing, not a difference in capability to assess probabilities.